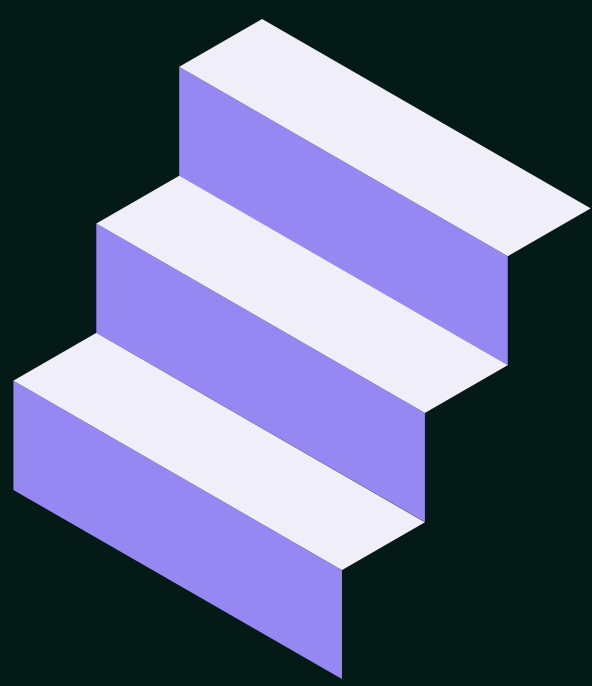




PeerLadder

A national peer-mentoring initiative supporting underrepresented dRTP leaders

Saskia Lawson-Tovey¹, Xenia Perez-Sitja², Sara Villa³, Carole Goble¹

¹University of Manchester · ²Earlham Institute · ³OLS

inspired by **ELEAD**

ELIXIR Leadership programme – the team behind PeerLadder are all ELEAD alumni

PeerLadder is a new peer-mentoring initiative in the UK.

- ↑ Supporting leadership development
- ↑ Empowering underrepresented digital Research Technical Professionals (dRTPs)
- ↑ Building confidence, community, and inclusive leadership

THE TEAM



Saskia Lawson-Tovey
University of Manchester
PI · ELEAD cohort 2



Xenia Perez-Sitja
Earlham Institute
ELEAD cohort 1 · co-lead cohort 2



Sara Villa
OLS
Co-lead · facilitator



Carole Goble
University of Manchester
Mentor · ELEAD cohorts 1 & 2

Why it matters

Diverse teams outperform – **but only when people feel safe enough to speak**. PeerLadder is built on both findings.

80%

of senior leadership roles in research-adjacent fields are held by white men. Women hold just **15%** of managing-director roles globally.

MCKINSEY & COMPANY (2023)

+121%

more patent citations from engineering teams with higher diversity, and **+19%** more revenue – evidence that diverse teams drive research-technical innovation.

ROYAL ACADEMY OF ENGINEERING (2024) · BSA / APPG ON DIVERSITY & INCLUSION IN STEM (2025)

The mechanism: **psychological safety**

Hiring people from underrepresented groups doesn't change outcomes on its own. They have to **feel safe to speak**, disagree, and admit uncertainty.

Amy Edmondson (Harvard Business School) calls this *psychological safety* – the variable that makes diversity work.

Google's **Project Aristotle** studied 180 teams and found psychological safety to be the **#1 factor** distinguishing high-performing teams.

The three rungs

01

Structured peer-mentoring

Regular small-group sessions with clear agendas, action commitments and accountability.

02

Leadership training from **OLS**

Skills development through the Open Life Science programme – facilitation, feedback, navigating power.

03

Psychological safety & guidance

Supportive materials and a facilitated space where it's safe to speak about real obstacles.

The cohort

15 dRTPs from **12 UK institutions**. Yellow dots on the map = institutions with a current mentee.

Who is in the cohort?

60%

women

47%

minority ethnic background

27%

neurodivergent

1/3

lower socioeconomic background

20%

main carers

13%

LGBTQIA+



dRTP roles in the cohort

- ▶ (Senior) Research Software Engineer
- ▶ Research Computing Systems Engineer
- ▶ Bioinformatics Technical Specialist
- ▶ Senior Research IT Business Partner
- ▶ Ecological Statistician
- ▶ Research Data Technical Specialist
- ▶ dRTP community coordinator
- ▶ Assistant Professor

Where in ELIXIR would you run it?

Stick a dot on the country where you'd want to host a PeerLadder-style scheme through your ELIXIR Node.



What was *your* leadership barrier?

Imposter syndrome? No mentor? No time? Bias? Something else? Write it on a post-it and pin it here – anonymous.

FUNDED BY



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peerladder.elixiruknode.org